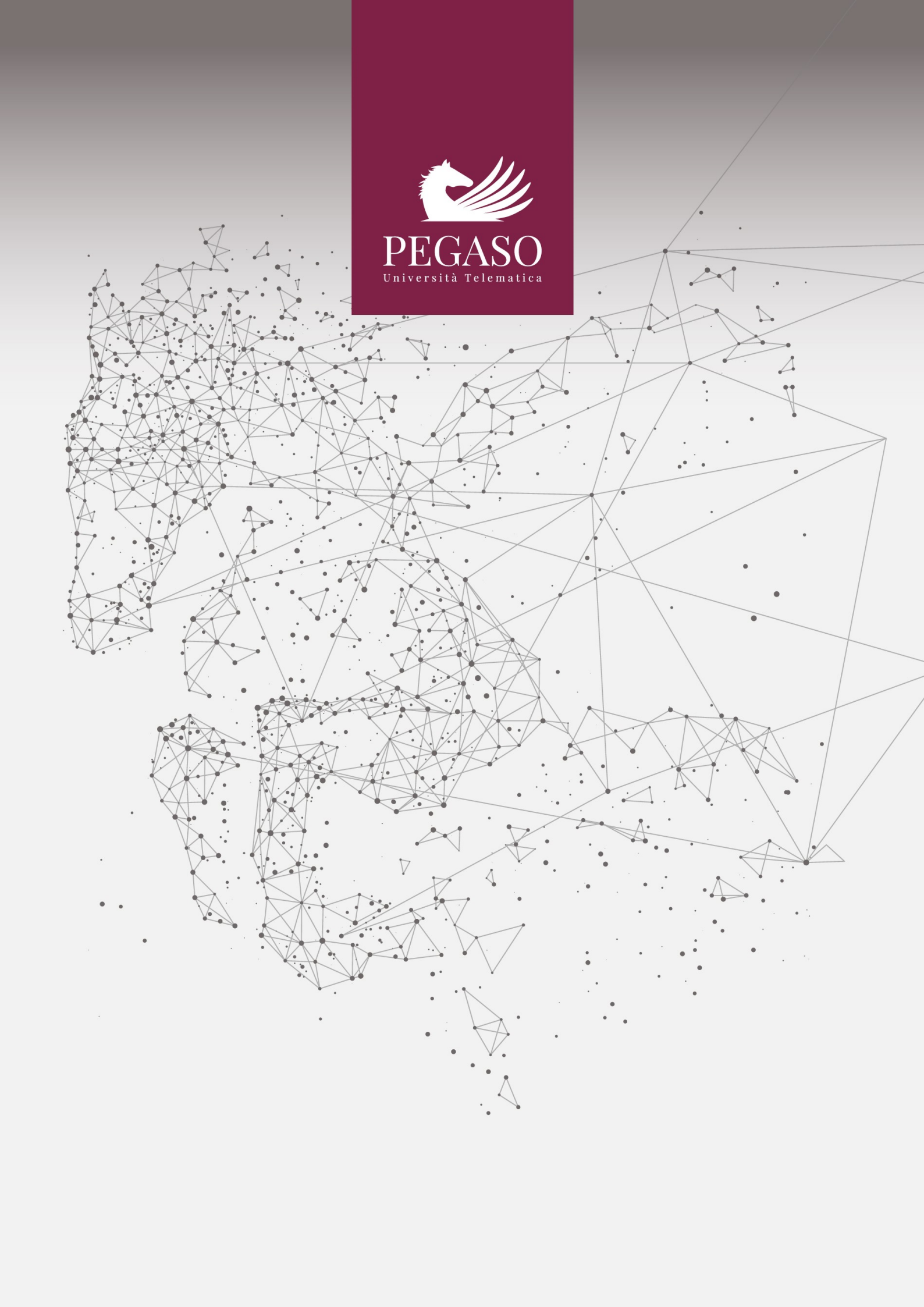

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1. Introduction and Going to

The number of verb forms used in English to talk about the future is considered one of the most difficult parts of the language. Differently to many other languages, future forms in English only indicate our attitudes towards the future events we want to talk about. For example, we use a different future form for each of the following: to express a future event that is thought of as something decided with someone else; a future idea that is thought of as a plan one makes on their own, such as an intention; or something that is thought of as a future prediction. We also use one structure for future predictions for which we have present evidence and another form for a prediction for which we only have our own opinions, beliefs or prior experience. It is also important, for example, to know if we want to express that a plan we have was decided before speaking or was spontaneously decided on while speaking in order to choose the form to help us communicate that distinction.

If we think of tenses as involving changes in the verb, then English doesn't in fact have many future tenses. Instead, we use a variety of forms (some of which are tenses used in their own right for other purposes (present continuous and present simple), modal verbs (of which **will** plays a part) and "modal-like" structures (like **be + going to**) to talk about the future.

Affirmative

be + going to + infinitive

The contraction can be made with the subject and the verb **be**:

I'm going to wash my hair this evening. She's going to leave university next spring.

Negative

be + not + going to + infinitive

The contraction can be made with the verb **be** and **not** (note: this is not possible with the phrases with the subject **I**):

I'm not going to call him today. I am not going to leave early. (I amn't…)

She isn't going to meet us at the pub.

They aren't going to hire a new receptionist.

Interrogative (inversion of be and subject)

be + subject + going to + infinitive

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Are you going to take the job?

Is he going to speak with his team about the new play?

No contractions are possible in the interrogative.

We use **going to** to talk about things that have already been decided and which we want to communicate as general ideas, intentions or plans which may not be organized at the time of the communication.

She's decided she's going to lose ten kilos.

I'm going to look for a new job. (= This is my intention. I decided this a few days ago.)

Max has got a new job. We're going to organize a party for him to say goodbye. (= This is our idea, but we don't have any fixed plans yet.)

Where are you going to have the wedding reception?

Be careful: We cannot use will/shall + infinitive in this case.

With the verb **GO**, we tend to eliminate **to** in this future form. This makes the form look exactly like the present continuous. We do this because the repetition "**going** to **go"** sounds less natural although the form is grammatically correct. Therefore, the choice to eliminate **to** is a personal choice.

I'm going to go to the dentist later. (or I'm going to the dentist...)

She's going to go to Paris in March. (or She's going to Paris in March)[1]

Predictions

We use **going to** to talk about things that are certain to happen because there is present evidence. We consider this prediction objective in nature and not based on how someone thinks or feels.

I've got no sense of direction - I know I'm going to get lost. (It is evident to me.)

Look out - you're going to fall! (The danger is clear)

Be careful: We cannot use will/shall + infinitive or the present continuous in this case.[2]

[1] H. Stephenson, J. Hughes, P. Dummett, *Life Intermediate Student Book Second Edition*, Hampshire, National Geographic Learning, 2019 (162)
[2] J. Bell and A. Thomas, *Gold First Coursebook New Edition*, Essex, Pearson Education Limited, 2014 (177)

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2. Present Continuous

We also use the present continuous to talk about things that have already been decided (not spontaneous plans made while speaking).

The present continuous is used to talk about a fixed arrangement to do something at a specified (or understood) time in the future. We often use the present continuous when we have agreed to do something with another person, we have bought tickets for something, etc.

I'm meeting my boss at 3.30. (= We both have the meeting in our diary.)

She's flying to New York next week (= She's already got her ticket.)

We often use the present continuous to ask people about their plans, especially when we want to make an invitation,

A: Are you doing anything tonight?

B: No, not this evening.

A: Would you like to go and see a film?[3]

[3] H. Stephenson, J. Hughes, P. Dummett, *Life Intermediate Student Book Second Edition*, Hampshire, National Geographic Learning, 2019 (162)

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3. Will – Future Simple

This form is often called the Future Simple and is formed by the modal verb **will** and the main verb in the infinitive. You should remember that **will** has only one form for all subjects (like all other modal verbs).

Interrogative: **will + infinitive**

Negative: **will + not + infinitive**

Interrogative (inversion of subject and will): **will + subject + infinitive**

Contractions with WILL

We often contract the **subject** and **WILL** in affirmative sentences:

I will	I'll
you will	you'll
he will she will it will	he'll she'll it'll
we will	we'll
they will	they'll

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In negative sentences, we may contract **WILL** with **NOT**, in this way:

I will not	I won't
you will not	you won't
he will not she will not it will not	he won't she won't it won't
we will not	we won't
they will not	they won't

In questions there are no contractions.

In short answers there are no contractions in the affirmative. However, the contraction of will + not in the negative short answer is possible.

Will she accept your offer? No, I believe she won’t.

WILL is used to refer to the future in a few ways:

Offers, Promises, Requests and Threats

If you tell anyone, I'll kill you!

I promise I'll pay the money back.

I'll meet you at the station if you want.

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Shall I meet you at the station?

Will you do the washing-up for me?

Watch out! We cannot use going to in this case.[4]

When a request, offer or suggestion is in a question form, we use:

Shall + I / we + infinitive

Shall I help you with that homework?

Shall we go out for dinner or stay in?

You look hot. Shall I open the window for you?

Decisions Made Spontaneously

We use will + infinitive to talk about future actions decided at the time of speaking.

I think I'll give up smoking.

I'll wear my black dress since I've just ironed it.

A: Have you sent Martin the email? B: No - I'll do it now.

I will help you with your presentation.

We will study for the exam together tomorrow.

Be careful: Because **going to** and present continuous are for decisions made before speaking, it is **not** possible to use these future forms in this case.

Predictions

We also use predicting something based on our belief or our knowledge of characteristic behavior. We consider this prediction subjective in nature and so it is based on opinion, belief and experience.

You'll feel better when you've had a good night's rest.

Be careful: We cannot use the present continuous in this case.

We often use **subject + think/believe** before this verb form in predictions to make the subjective nature of it clear.

When making a prediction about an event that someone thinks is unlikely to happen, we tend to negate the verb phrase with **think/believe** instead of using **will + not**.

[4] J. Bell and A. Thomas, *Gold First Coursebook New Edition*, Essex, Pearson Education Limited, 2014 (177)

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I think it won't rain. (better= I don't think it will rain.)

They think it won't be successful to train the horse to jump. (better= They don't think it will be successful…)

The most common way to ask somebody to make a prediction is Do you think + will.

Do you think Jackie will like the present?

We use will and won't when we are confident about a prediction. We often add adverbs like certainly, definitely and probably to make a prediction sound stronger.

Adverbs like these normally come:

after will

My job will definitely be very different in the future.

before won't

She definitely won't believe you.

Future Facts

Will is also used to communicate a future situation when it is considered something that was not decided or predicted by the speaker or for events that we cannot control.

I will be 47 on my next birthday.

You can call me anytime tomorrow. I will be at home.

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4. Present Simple and Some Modal Verbs

Present Simple

We use the present simple for an event that follows a regular schedule or timetable, like the time of trains, flights, etc.

My flight leaves at 6.34 am.

My class finishes at 9.30 pm.

Note: We don't normally use the present simple to talk about an arrangement with other people. We use present continuous or going to instead.

We're all meeting in the square at 8 pm. (We all meet in the square at 8 pm.)[5]

The present simple also has an important role in **future time clauses**. We use future time clauses to indicate the moment for a future event.

Future time clauses begin with time words such as when, as soon as, after, before, until, and while. Below are a few example sentences. Notice that a comma separates the time clause from the main clause when the time clause comes first.

When I finish the dishes, I'll help you with your homework.

I'll help you with your homework when I finish the dishes.

As soon as I finish the dishes, I'll help you with your homework.

I'll help you with your homework as soon as I finish the dishes.

After I finish the dishes, I'll help you with your homework.

I'll help you with your homework after I finish the dishes.

Before I go home, I'll finish this report.

I'll finish this report before I go home.

Until I finish this report, I won't go home.

I won't go home until I finish this report.

[5] H. Stephenson, J. Hughes, P. Dummett, *Life Intermediate Student Book Second Edition*, Hampshire, National Geographic Learning, 2019 (162)

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Some Modal Verbs

All modal verbs have only one form for all subjects (I, you, he/ she/ it, etc.) and to make negatives we simply add **not** to the modal verb and in questions we use simple inversion of the subject and modal. These verbs are always followed by the basic infinitive form of another non-modal main verb.

It may rain.

She may come for a visit if she has the weekend free.

We use **may/might/could** to talk about the possibility of something in the present or the future, when we are making a guess about a present situation, or we aren't sure if something will happen in the future.

The company may need to close the factory.

They might not give me the job as I don't have much experience.

The temperature is going down fast, it might/may/could snow tonight.

I'm not sure but we could be running late for tomorrow's meeting because of the bus strike in the morning.

Meaning and use of Might, May and Could

I might go to the exhibition at the Museum of Modern Art this afternoon. (future)

He's traveling in Hungary. He may be in Budapest by now. (present)

We could have some problems later this month. (future)

There is almost no difference in meaning between might, may and could.

We use **might not/mightn't** and **may not** to talk about negative possibility. We don't usually use a contraction for **may not**. We cannot use **could not/couldn't** for possibility in the same way as **might not** and **may not**.

We **might not move** into the new house until the New Year.

Our children **may not agree** with our suggestions.

May vs. Might for Likelihood

May suggests a strong likelihood of something occurring (e.g., She actually **may** get a raise this year). **Might**, on the other hand, indicates a lower likelihood of something happening (e.g., If we leave now for the station, we might make our train).

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Should

We use **should** to give the idea that something is expected in the future.

As far as I know, the ferry is running on schedule. We should arrive in Vancouver in about an hour.

Let's stop by their house on the way home. They should be home by the time we get there.

Would

We use **would** for a hypothetical situation or for imagined future situations which are usually considered unlikely. The most common usage of this modal is in the second conditional structure.

I would go to Madrid next weekend, if I didn't have to work.

Would you move to another city if you were hired by a good company there?

A: Can I help you with the washing up? B: Thank you. That would be lovely.

Notice that **would** is often contracted with the subject in affirmative phrases and with **not** in negatives. I should not be confused with the verb HAVE as an auxiliary verb in the past simple.

I'd really love to visit The British Museum. (I would really love…)

She'd been to London before. (She had been to London.)

EXERCISES

Read the sentences (1-6). Choose the correct option (a or b) to explain each sentence.

1. I'm getting a new computer tomorrow.

a I plan to buy a new one.

b I've already chosen and ordered one.

2. I'll have some coffee, please.

a I'd already decided to have this.

b I've just decided that I want this.

3. He's going to retake his exam.

a He's just decided to do this.

b He plans to do this.

4. We leave at 6:45 tomorrow morning.

a The train leaves at this time.

b We plan to leave at this time.

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5. He's moving abroad for work.

a He plans to do this.

b He's already got his contract.

6. I'll come to the shop with you after lunch.

a I've just decided to do this.

b We've already arranged to do this.

Complete the conversations with the correct future form. Sometimes more than one form is possible.

7. A: Sorry, Adrien is busy right now. B: OK, I _____(come) back later.

8. A: Do you want to go out tomorrow evening? B: Sorry, I_____(go) to the theatre. I've already bought a ticket.

9. A: What are you doing this evening? B: I _____ (study) because I have an exam soon.

10. A: Are you hungry? How about going out for a meal? B: No, it's OK – I_____(make) something to eat.

11. A: When do you need to be at the station? B: My train_____(leave) at 8:23, so I need to be there at about 8:15.

Look at the underlined verbs. Which ones are examples of the present continuous, present simple, will, going to and modal verbs?

A: Who do you think will get the main part?

B: I expect (12) it'll be Zoe. She's a good singer and dancer. But it (13) could be Molly. I thought she did a good audition too. Mr Paton says (14) he's going to tell us in class this week.

A: When (15) *are you starting* rehearsals?

B: On Friday. (16) It's going to be really hard work because performances (17) start in three weeks.

(18) I'll help you learn your lines, if you'd like.

Thanks. That would be very helpful.

Now match the numbered future forms (12-18) in the dialogue above with their uses A-G.

A. an offer

B. a fixed arrangement

C. a timetabled event in the future

D. an intention - something that someone has decided to do in the future

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E. a prediction based on a belief or opinion

F. a prediction - based on fact

G. a future possibility

19. Translate the following text into Italian.

I left school last month. I'm going to take the summer off, but in September I'm starting as an apprentice in a garage. I'm doing an evening course as well which starts in October. I'm lucky - some of my friends don't know what they are going to do in the future because they just can't seem to decide on the right path. I believe that they will find inspiration in the activities they are pursuing now and they will know better what they want to do soon. We're meeting next week for the first time since our exams. I'm not sure but we might talk about all of these things then. Actually, I think I'll send sending them a message to confirm our meeting now.

EXERCISE ANSWER KEY

1. b
2. b
3. b
4. a
5. b
6. a
7. I'll come back later.
8. I'm going to the theater.
9. I'm going to study…
10. I'll make something to eat.
11. My train leaves at 8:23,…
12. E
13. G
14. D
15. B
16. F
17. C
18. A

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19. Ho finito la scuola il mese scorso. Prenderò l'estate libera, ma a settembre inizierò a lavorare come apprendista in un'officina. Seguirò anche un corso serale che inizierà a ottobre. Sono fortunato: alcuni miei amici non sanno cosa faranno in futuro perché non riescono a decidere che strada prendere. Credo che troveranno ispirazione nelle attività che stanno svolgendo ora e presto sapranno meglio cosa vogliono fare. Ci incontreremo la prossima settimana per la prima volta dopo gli esami. Non ne sono sicuro, ma forse in quel momento parleremo di tutte queste cose. Anzi, credo che gli manderò un messaggio per confermare il nostro incontro.

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